

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake

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Intrahepatic Cholestasis of Pregnancy (ICP)

A liver condition causing intense itching — requires monitoring and management

WHAT IS ICP?

Intrahepatic cholestasis of pregnancy (ICP) is a liver condition where bile acids build up in the blood because bile flow from the liver slows. It typically appears in the **second or third trimester**. It affects about **1–2 in 1,000 pregnancies** in the U.S., and is more common in women of South American or Scandinavian descent.

RISK FACTORS

- Personal or family history of ICP
- Previous ICP pregnancy (recurrence risk 60–70%)
- Twin or multiple pregnancy
- Gallbladder disease or gallstones
- South American, Scandinavian, or Chilean heritage
- Hepatitis C infection
- Prior oral contraceptive pill-induced liver issues

SYMPTOMS

- **Intense itching** — especially palms and soles, worse at night
- No rash (distinguishes ICP from PUPPS)
- Dark urine or pale/greasy stools
- Mild jaundice (yellowing of skin/eyes) — rare
- Fatigue and loss of appetite
- Right upper abdominal discomfort
- Itching often worsens as pregnancy progresses

DIAGNOSIS

- Serum bile acids — **key diagnostic test**
- Liver function tests (ALT, AST, bilirubin)
- Values typically elevated by 3rd trimester
- Bile acids ≥ 10 $\mu\text{mol/L}$ diagnostic; ≥ 40 $\mu\text{mol/L}$ severe
- Ultrasound to evaluate gallbladder
- Repeat labs every 1–2 weeks to monitor

TREATMENT

- **Ursodeoxycholic acid (UDCA)** — first-line treatment **RX**
- UDCA reduces bile acids, improves itching
- Antihistamines (Benadryl) for itch relief **OTC**
- Sarna lotion, cool baths, loose cotton clothing
- Weekly nonstress tests starting at 32–34 weeks
- Early delivery typically recommended at 37 weeks
- Vitamin K supplement may be prescribed

FETAL RISKS

- Increased risk of preterm birth
- Fetal distress during labor
- Stillbirth risk — **especially with bile acids ≥ 40 $\mu\text{mol/L}$**
- Meconium-stained fluid
- Risk correlates with severity of bile acid elevation
- Condition resolves for mother after delivery

⚠️ CALL YOUR DOCTOR RIGHT AWAY

- ⚠️ New onset of intense itching, especially at night
- ⚠️ Jaundice (yellow skin or eyes)
- ⚠️ Fever with abdominal pain
- ⚠️ Itching spreading to rest of body
- ⚠️ Decreased fetal movement
- ⚠️ Dark urine or pale stools
- ⚠️ Contractions before 37 weeks
- ⚠️ Right upper quadrant pain

♥️ With Careful Monitoring, Outcomes Are Excellent

ICP is treatable and manageable with close monitoring. Most babies born to mothers with ICP do very well, especially when the condition is caught early and managed with medication and timely delivery. Itching typically resolves within days of delivery. Your team will keep you and your baby safe every step of the way.